

A Regime Theory of Joy

This article presents the theoretical framework on which the M-ZRT is based and includes a practical example of a session.

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A Regime Theory of Joy is a theoretical framework I developed independently to explain the mechanisms underlying joy. It proposes that joy is not merely a reward state but a distinct access regime. According to this framework, the emergence of joy depends on the temporary suspension of premature cognitive closure. When evaluative closure processes (Z) are sufficiently reduced, the state is able to continue developing until it undergoes a threshold-like transition into autonomous deployment.

The second contribution of this work is the proposal of a task designed to induce joy.

Originality of the theoretical framework. To the best of our knowledge, this framework is the first to propose action coupling as the primary variable governing access to joy and to derive from this principle a systematic set of behavioral perturbations designed to reduce it.

Before Beginning the Task

This task is hypothesized to facilitate a transition toward a distinct brain regime in which comparison, anticipation, and evaluation temporarily become less dominant, allowing a mode of functioning in which optimization is temporarily suspended.

Consequently, approaching the protocol as a problem to solve already shifts cognition away from the regime it is intended to produce. Constructing hierarchies has the same effect, since hierarchies depend on comparison. Similarly, questions such as "Which exercise should I do?" or "How often should I perform it?" engage the very cognitive processes that the protocol is designed to suspend.

The protocol therefore begins by treating all available options as equally acceptable. Only from this position can the task begin.

Not performing an exercise is not considered a failure but simply one of the acceptable outcomes.

Before beginning, it may be helpful to say to yourself once, "There is nothing to optimize here." This sentence is intended as a single local action requiring no verification. Repeating it in the hope of making the protocol more effective would itself reintroduce optimization into the task.

An attempt to optimize would therefore shift cognitive processing back toward the opposite regime.

Protocol

Do not repeat the exercises excessively. Several attempts spread over a period of days may be required before a meaningful transition occurs. The principal cause of failure is doing too much, therefore perform no more than one attempt per day.

The aim is to induce a regime shift. It is therefore expected that the current regime may resist the attempt rather than cooperate with it. It may even encourage abandoning the exercise altogether.

One way the current regime may maintain itself is by subtly reducing interest in the exercise. Thoughts such as "This isn't for me" may arise. If the goal is to facilitate a regime shift, it is preferable to continue despite these reactions, without attempting to suppress or analyze them.

The current regime is generally able to optimize rest, but not to suspend optimization itself. Yet this is precisely what the M-ZRT (Minimal Z-Reduction Task) is designed to do.

Simply acknowledge these reactions and continue normally. If the protocol feels confusing, raises questions, or even seems somewhat unpleasant, this is consistent with the hypothesis that the current regime does not readily accommodate the temporary suspension of optimization.

The exercises are intentionally minimal. As with falling asleep, additional effort or complexity may interfere with the process rather than facilitate it.

The Core Task

Each exercise can be repeated approximately four to five times before moving on to the next. There is no need to rush.

- Read short text fragments from different places. They do not need to form a coherent whole.
- Perform a small movement without comparing it to a before or an after.
- For a brief moment, let two nearby objects seem equally worthy of attention.
- For a brief moment, nothing needs to become the first priority.
- Briefly notice an object before it becomes something to use. 'just an object'.
- For a brief moment, look at a completely ordinary object as if it were highly important.

- Look at the time without immediately judging whether it is early, late, good, bad, useful, or problematic.
- Launch a music video. During the first ten seconds, do not evaluate the media or your reaction to it, and do not adjust the volume. Media begins → No evaluation. Volume → No adjustment.

These exercises briefly disrupt automatic action recruitment, temporarily reducing the level of Z and thereby increasing the probability of a transition to another regime. By contrast, when an exercise is performed with analysis, anticipation, or verification of its effects, a different set of action policies is automatically recruited, increasing Z instead.

Optional Exercises for Walking Outdoors

Briefly pick up an ordinary stone as if it were rare. Hold it for a few seconds, then place it back. Ordinary stone → Rare stone.

For a brief moment, let both sides of the street seem equally acceptable. Then continue normally. Left side $\approx$ Right side.

Rationale for the Task

In *A Regime Theory of Joy*, joy refers to a specific positive affective state characterized by a pleasant sensation radiating from the chest together with heightened olfactory sensitivity. This distinctive phenomenology helps, at least in part, to rule out an explanation based solely on a placebo effect or on the novelty of the task.

The increase in olfactory sensitivity may reflect greater engagement of the hippocampal system. If so, the hippocampus, through its role in contextual memory and associative processing, could enrich the variety and diversity of subjective experience, producing a broader range of positive experiential "textures."

In this state, colors may appear exceptionally vivid, almost as though they had a sweet taste. Odors can evoke the feeling of entering another world, and small shimmering objects may spontaneously elicit particularly rich mental imagery.

This may explain why certain moments, particularly during childhood, when access to this state is hypothesized to be easier, are often experienced and remembered as unique.

A common assumption is that the environment itself produces this feeling. The framework proposed here instead suggests that the environment primarily acts as an amplifier of a brain configuration that is already accessible.

In principle, this hypothesis implies that it could be theoretically possible to remain in such a positive state indefinitely.

Joy as a Problem of Causal Rigidity

According to **A Regime Theory of Joy**, the principal obstacle to the emergence of joy is neither a lack of reward nor a dopaminergic deficit, but the progressive rigidification of acquired causal chains. Through learning, the brain accumulates countless cause-and-effect relationships that organize perception and behavior. This cumulative rigidity is represented by the variable **Z**.

As **Z** increases, it progressively recruits a control regime specialized for prediction, optimization, and the production of reliable actions. This regime is incompatible with the ease regime associated with joy.

Imagine a desk containing a computer and a pencil. Each object recruits a large network of learned causal relationships, action tendencies, and predictions. A pencil is typically assigned less value than a computer and is therefore treated as more easily replaceable. It is grasped in a particular way, used while monitoring spelling, returned to its usual location, and often checked afterward to ensure it has not been misplaced.

These rules are also linked to object categorization. A pencil is perceived as "just a pencil," whereas a computer is regarded as valuable because of its many functions. Each object therefore automatically recruits its customary meaning together with the actions normally associated with it.

As learning accumulates, behavior becomes increasingly organized around local optimization. Each selected action automatically recruits the next preferred action policy.

The **M-ZRT** introduces brief discontinuities into these chains before they become fully stabilized (Appendix 1).

Why the M-ZRT Targets Optimization

Some exercises briefly perturb object categories, others interrupt familiar action sequences, while others deliberately leave a sequence incomplete. Together, these micro-perturbations are hypothesized to reduce the rigidity of the underlying action structure, thereby increasing the probability that the ease regime will emerge.

Each M-ZRT exercise is effective only if the brain treats it as a minor, inconsequential perturbation. This is the central challenge of the method. It is also difficult because it runs counter to the principles of flow, a deeply ingrained mode of operation. For this reason, the task is psychologically counterintuitive.

If the exercises are approached too seriously, the brain naturally reinstates comparison, evaluation, prediction, and monitoring. According to the theory, this reactivates the control regime that competes with the ease regime. From that point onward, the task no longer increases the probability of entering a state compatible with joy, it may even reduce it.

To illustrate this principle, consider the exercise "**Modify Your Path.**"

Under ordinary circumstances, a player in an RPG walks directly toward their destination. In this exercise, they introduce a slight deviation for no particular purpose. For example, they may change direction for a second or casually walk around an insignificant object before returning to their original route.

The primary activity remains moving through the game world. The alteration of the path is the perturbation.

Beginners often find this exercise surprisingly difficult because it interrupts an action sequence that is already underway. Interestingly, many people find it easier to complete a complex task than to introduce a small arbitrary perturbation into an ongoing action. For some, solving a puzzle or meditating requires less effort than walking in a slightly different direction for two seconds.

With practice, however, more advanced exercises gradually become easier as well.

Conclusion

Once these exercises are understood and performed naturally, they may already have been sufficient to produce a brief episode of joy, or even to open the ease regime.

They can be applied across a wide variety of contexts, and some target the mechanisms of action more directly and more strongly than others.

The broader objective is to maintain the ease regime even in evaluative environments (Appendix 2), a problem that the present theoretical framework naturally seeks to address.

References:

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. *SSRN*, <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>

Morin, Florian, Evaluative Monitoring and Access to Intense Positive Affect: The Minimal Z-Reduction Task Framework (June 06, 2026). Available at SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=6888300> or <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6888300>

Appendix 1 Other Exercises

These exercises are provided for informational purposes. Remember that trying to optimize the task goes against its very principle. The principal cause of failure is doing too many of them.

- Briefly look at an ordinary object as if it belonged in a museum. Then immediately return to using it normally. Ordinary object → Museum exhibit → Ordinary object.
- For a brief moment, hold an object that is about to be thrown away as if it were a treasure, then place it in the trash without hesitation. Trash → Treasure → Trash.
- For a brief moment, treat two different objects as having the same value Chair ≈ Lamp.
- For a brief moment, treat two options as equally acceptable. Option A ≈ Option B
- After looking at the time, briefly imagine that a different time appears instead.
- Briefly look at one visual detail that is currently irrelevant. Door → Wood grain
- Open something. Whatever is there can simply be what is there. Folder opens → Whatever is there.
- Look at an ordinary object and briefly experience it as not entirely matching its usual category. Chair → Not quite a chair
- Look at an object and allow two different associations to become possible at the same time. For example, chair → "satellite" and "animal." Do not choose between them.
- After picking up an object, let it remain in your hand briefly before using it.

Appendix 2 Environnement

Element	Prevents entry	Disrupts an already open regime	Hypothesized mechanism
Having a "priority"	Yes	Yes	Action hierarchy, selection of a dominant goal
Preferring one place	Yes	Yes	Value assignment, comparison, selection

Preferring one person	Yes	Yes	Social hierarchy, relational valuation, implicit expectations
Preferring one object	Yes	Yes	Value assignment, selective focus
Working toward a goal considered more important or meaningful than others	Yes	Yes	Hierarchical organization of action around a global objective
Working with a sense of progress	Yes	Yes	Progress monitoring, accumulation, comparison with a previous state
Working while keeping the action local	Often No	Often No	Action remains confined to the present moment, without accumulation or a global objective
Going somewhere for a specific purpose	Yes	Yes	Goal-directed movement, anticipation of an outcome
Having a scheduled appointment	Yes	Yes	Temporal anticipation, maintenance of a future intention
Expecting an effect, for example expecting to enjoy the sun or expecting music to improve one's mood	Yes	Yes	Outcome anticipation, implicit verification of the expected effect

Viewing an object primarily as useful	Yes	Yes	Functional recruitment, action preparation
Decorating as a way of optimizing the environment	Yes	Yes	Environmental correction, search for the best arrangement
Being meticulous or perfectionistic	Yes	Yes	Verification, correction, high standards
Using social media	Yes	Yes	Social comparison, novelty, variable rewards, implicit evaluation
Watching the news	Yes	Yes	Vigilance, continuous evaluation, event salience
Shopping	Yes	Yes	Comparison, choice, optimization, value assignment
Meditating as a goal-directed practice or technique	Yes	Yes	Attentional control, monitoring of internal state
Reading novels	Yes	Yes	Narrative construction, anticipation, mental continuity
Watching films, excluding absurd content	Yes	Yes	Narrative recruitment, engagement with characters' goals

Non-absurd humor	Yes	Variable	Context processing, incongruity resolution, social judgment
Old-fashioned, naive television films	Often No	Often No	Low narrative pressure, low perceptual optimization, familiar and undemanding content
Watching a music video	Variable to No	Often No	Sensory stimulation, limited narrative continuity, perceptual engagement
Listening actively to music, rather than as background	Yes	Variable	Voluntary attentional orientation, expectation of an effect, prioritized emotional processing
Listening to music in the background	Often No	Often No	Low attentional recruitment, passive integration into the environment
Taking medication	Yes	Variable	Expectation of an effect, goal-directed regulation of internal state
Intentionally holding a posture	Yes	Variable	Sustained motor control, maintenance of an instruction
Chronic symptoms	Yes	Variable to Yes	Recurrent bodily monitoring, attention

			repeatedly drawn to the body
Headache	No	No, may paradoxically increase joy	Empirical exception, possible contrast effect or altered relationship to bodily sensations
High temperature	Yes	Yes	Physiological discomfort, thermoregulation, increased bodily attentional recruitment
Low temperature	Yes	Variable to Yes	Thermoregulation, bodily discomfort, increased physiological vigilance
Viewing an open landscape, such as the sea, plains, mountains, or the horizon	Often No	Often No	Perceptual openness, low functional recruitment
Viewing a large open structure, such as a cathedral, historic train station, or spacious hall	Variable to No	Often No	Sense of space, perceptual exploration, low immediate action pressure
Viewing a highly optimized large building, such as office buildings, modern shopping centers, or industrial complexes	Yes	Variable to Yes	Functional salience, visible optimization, instrumental purpose embedded in

